

# news feed

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## hypothesis

### Aura Communications wireless headset

#### ■ What is it?

It is a magnetic induction based hands-free headset for mobile phones. Unlike traditional wireless headsets, it has a limited range of just over a meter, and works on a single AA alkaline battery

#### ■ How does it work?

The Aura uses a form of magnetic induction to transmit the signals from the phone to the headset, and vice versa. It works by changing a faint magnetic field between the base and the headset. Hence it does not use radio frequency (RF) to wirelessly transmit calls, unlike today's Bluetooth headsets.

#### ■ What does it do?

The Aura headset provides a low cost alternative to Bluetooth headsets. The base unit interfaces with most current generation mobile phones, through the ear-phone socket. The single AA battery gives up to 25 hours of talk time, much more than Bluetooth headsets.

## Good-bye old cams

Kodak has decided to stop selling film-based cameras in USA, Canada and Western Europe, and will concentrate on pushing one-time use cameras in this region. However, it will continue to sell film-based cameras in other regions.

Kodak will focus on the high-volume digital camera

market. According to InfoTrends Research Group, global film camera shipments this year will be 36 million units against 48 million in 2003. Digital camera shipments, on the other hand, will rise to 53 million in 2004, from 41 million units in 2003.

Kodak has identified India, China, Eastern Europe

and Latin America as its core film-based camera markets. The company estimates there are 60 million Chinese consumers who have the purchasing power, but have not bought their first camera yet. However, Kodak will remain in the film business as 120 million film rolls are still sold ever year.

## Google on Wall Street

Google's long-awaited Initial Public Offering (IPO) may be just around the corner. The still-privately held company has hired two leading investment banks—Morgan Stanley and Goldman Sachs—to spearhead their IPO process.

There is no formal announcement yet, but industry insiders believe the offering may take place around April this year, raising as much as \$4 billion.

It is believed that only a third of Google's entire stock—expected to be worth \$12 billion—is going to be put up in the IPO, so the owners

would still control adequate stocks. Google also has a hand in Usenet



ILLUSTRATIONS: Mahesh Benkar

archives, image searching, news aggregation, language services and recently acquired Blogger—the Web logging software company.

## Spicing the post

The old meets the new, the ancient meets the post-modern—Bangalore-based Spice Telecom could well believe it has started a new trend, thanks to its innovative tie-up with, hold your breath, the Postal Department. Customers can now just walk into their nearest post-office and buy prepaid

mobile phone cards and refill coupons of all commonly issued denominations. Spice has introduced the service in Bangalore and Mysore, and will gradually be extended to more post offices in other post as demand picks up. Technology and communications, the synergy never looked better!

## Microsoft in a new mood

Microsoft had earlier announced it would end extended support for Windows 98 and 98SE on January 16, 2004, and Windows Me on December 31, 2004. But, but, but... the company has realised that a lot of people in developing countries still use Windows 98 and Windows Me, and so it will continue supporting the operating systems till June 30, 2006.

Reports indicate that 90 per cent of all computer users across the world use Windows—20 per cent of which still use Windows 98. The company said the newer versions of Windows—Windows XP and Windows 2000—have a support lifecycle of seven years. Thus, by extending support for Windows 98 and Me, they are complying with current support policies.



## snapshot

Computer virus attacks cost the business world \$55 billion in damages in 2003

Source: Trend Micro

■ AT&T Wireless, the third-largest US cellphone service provider is now on sale ■ HP's Linux products and services netted the company \$2.5 billion in 2003